



The Red Sea Coast

The margins of the world's most northerly tropical sea with magnificent reefs and the site of a new ocean in the making

The Red Sea is an inlet of the Indian Ocean and has coasts on seven countries—Egypt, Israel, Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Sudan, Eritrea, and Yemen. It stretches for 1,400 miles (2,250 km) over a tectonic plate boundary where the Arabian Plate is gradually moving away from the African Plate—a process that will eventually create a new ocean (see p.185).

Red Sea reefs

Reflecting the fact that it sits over an area where Earth's crust is rifting apart, the center of the Red Sea plunges to a maximum depth of 7,254 ft (2,211 m). However, most of

its coast is rimmed by shallow submarine shelves and extensive fringing coral reefs (see panel, opposite). These are some of the most biologically well-endowed reefs, home to over 1,000 invertebrate species, 1,200 fish species, and several hundred types of hard and soft corals. With this rich marine life and high water clarity, the Red Sea Coast is a highly popular destination for scuba divers. Unfortunately, intense diving tourism, along with coastal development, has damaged the reefs in some areas.



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Africa

△ RIOT OF COLOR

Tiny green chromis fish surround scarlet and magenta soft corals—colonies of numerous minuscule animals called polyps—in a typical scene from a Red Sea reef.

▽ VIVID CORAL

This mushroom coral is one of over 300 different species of hard corals found on Red Sea reefs.

